

Estate 2023, traveling fast and safe, but without giving up privacy
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Summer is advancing, the thermometer is rising, the desire to work is decreasing, but fortunately, for many, the holidays are approaching. Many of us are about to set off by car, train, and plane. Good, indeed very good. And it is also good that with the holidays comes a bit of carefree spirit. However, the important thing is that this legitimate ambition for carefree enjoyment does not turn into yet another excuse to worry less about our privacy than we usually do.

The idea of an appeal for carefree enjoyment not to become recklessness is suggested by various news items that bounced around this week, news that tells how, especially in the transport sector, the use of increasingly invasive technologies that are ever more eager for personal data is becoming more frequent, in exchange for the promise to people, users, and travelers to get there faster, save time, arrive sooner, and exert less effort.

All things that always have a strong appeal for all of us, an appeal that grows disproportionately during the holidays. A nice investigation by the Washington Post this week, for example, tells of a couple of apps particularly popular in American airports that already count tens of millions of users who, in exchange for the collection of a significant amount of extraordinarily valuable personal data such as biometric data and the payment of a few dozen euros, promise travelers to spare them from waiting times and security checks at the gates and check-in. The apps in question are called Clear and PreCheck; the former is managed by a private company and the latter by the U.S. Department of Transportation. Industry insiders and activists, on the other side of the ocean, raise some suspicions – which do not seem entirely unfounded – regarding the sustainability, in terms of privacy protection, of the two applications. Especially if you plan to head towards the USA, it is probably worth reading the Washington Post article, as always, with a single objective: to understand and acquire a reasonable level of awareness before deciding whether the game is worth the candle, whether convenience justifies the acceptance of some additional risks regarding privacy, or whether, perhaps, it is not worth keeping to oneself, especially biometric data, and sacrificing a few extra minutes of your vacation on the altar of queues at security gates or check-in. After all, if we allow ourselves the right to choose, we might as well exercise it in the most conscious way possible.

Also because, as another news item that also bounced around this week and also from the USA tells, one cannot always choose. This is the case, for example, with intelligent facial recognition in airports, which, although still in the experimental phase, the Transportation Security Administration has announced it wants to extend to about 400 airports in the near future. This is causing a certain alarm that is difficult to consider unjustified among the most attentive defenders of civil rights. It is indeed contested that the TSA has not provided clear information. Moreover, Oregon State Senator Jeff Merkley stated that when he tried to opt-out of the TSA's voluntary facial recognition service, he was told that this would cause significant delays. As if to say: feel free to keep your biometric data to yourself, but do not think that it is a choice without consequences.

Obviously, this is not how it should go. But this kind of issue is not just for those traveling by plane. The New York subway is implementing an “artificial intelligence-powered” surveillance system to discourage free-riders who do not pay for their tickets, in order to stem annual losses of about 690 million dollars due to “scofflaws.” All treated as suspicious fare evaders, in short, even if only a few are actually so. Or, if you prefer, the biometric personal data of millions of people collected and processed – with all that entails even just in terms of risk – to protect the wallet of the company that manages the subway. To be clear, the problem exists and needs to be addressed, but it is not easy to find the balance point. Experts and activists, in this case as well, have risen up and are raising barricades against what they consider, in every respect, a mass surveillance initiative. And that the climate surrounding the use of this kind of technology is, politically speaking, heated is evidenced by the fact that a group of lawmakers, already in the spring, called for a moratorium (Facial Recognition and

Biometric Technology Moratorium Act) to block the use of facial recognition technologies by the federal government.

And on this side of the Ocean? We will have to wait until next summer to see what will apparently be the most developed large-scale mass surveillance system based on algorithms ever seen in Europe, which France will deploy during the 2024 Paris Olympics. We are still far away, but criticism is already raging, and some even speak of a “Napoleonic” tendency towards state control. There is time, at least the time necessary for a small pause, even if we should never put our rights on vacation.